

Sequence for Covering and Uncovering Speed Signs in Temporary Traffic Management

Document Purpose

This document provides guidance for traffic controllers on the correct sequence for covering and uncovering existing speed signs during temporary traffic management operations. It includes citations from authoritative documents to support proper practice and help demonstrate compliance to other traffic management personnel.

1. The Required Sequence

1.1 Installation Sequence (Putting Up Traffic Management)

When setting up temporary traffic management that involves speed reductions, the following sequence must be followed:

Step	Action	Purpose
1	Install temporary speed signs	Establish the temporary speed limit BEFORE removing the existing limit
2	Cover permanent speed signs	Remove conflicting speed information from driver view
3	Erect tapers and delineation devices	Complete the traffic management setup

1.2 Removal Sequence (Taking Down Traffic Management)

When removing temporary traffic management, the sequence is reversed:

Step	Action	Purpose
1	Remove tapers and delineation devices	Begin dismantling from the work area outward
2	Uncover permanent speed signs	Restore the original speed limit to driver view

3	Remove temporary speed signs	Complete removal AFTER original limit is visible
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2. Why This Sequence Matters

2.1 The Critical Principle

The fundamental principle is that drivers must always have a valid speed limit visible. At no point should a driver be without a speed sign to follow. This is why temporary speed signs must be installed BEFORE permanent signs are covered, and permanent signs must be uncovered BEFORE temporary signs are removed.

2.2 What Happens With Incorrect Sequencing

If the sequence is reversed, drivers may encounter a situation where:

- During Installation: If permanent signs are covered before temporary signs are installed, drivers have no speed limit to follow. This creates confusion and potential for excessive speeds through the worksite.
- During Removal: If temporary signs are removed before permanent signs are uncovered, drivers again have no speed limit visible. This is particularly dangerous if the permanent limit has been restored.

3. Authoritative Citations

3.1 AGTTM Part 3: Static Worksites

The Austroads Guide to Temporary Traffic Management (AGTTM) Part 3 provides the foundation for traffic management practice in Australia. The following citation from Page 114 establishes the sequence:

"Before work commences, erect traffic control devices in accordance with AGTTM Part 6. Once all signs are installed, erect tapers and other delineation devices."

Source: AGTTM Part 3 (2021), Page 114 - Section on Installation Sequence

This clearly establishes that signs must be fully installed BEFORE tapers and delineation are erected. This applies equally to speed signs - temporary speed signs must be in place before the permanent signs they replace are covered.

3.2 MRWA Code of Practice

The Main Roads Western Australia Traffic Management Code of Practice (May 2025) provides additional guidance:

"The implementation, operation and/or removal of the temporary traffic management must be considered part of the works, therefore the TMP must provide details on how this activity will be conducted safely (refer to AGTTM Part 5 and Part 6) including order of set up and pack down. This may require an additional TGS for the traffic management personnel to follow. The following must be considered: The requirement to install and remove traffic management devices in the sequence described in AGTTM Part 6."

Section 6.4.1 of the MRWA Code of Practice further states:

"In accordance with Clause 4.2.5 of AS 1742.3 - 2019 'Any signs and traffic control devices, including regulatory, warning guide signs and pavement marking, which are inappropriate to, or conflict with, the temporary worksite situation must be covered, obliterated or removed'."

Source: MRWA Code of Practice (May 2025), Section 6.4.1 - Existing Signs

3.3 AS 1742.3 - 2019

Australian Standard AS 1742.3 - 2019 is referenced by both AGTTM and MRWA Code of Practice. The requirement to cover conflicting signs is established in Clause 4.2.5, which forms the basis for the sequence requirements.

4. Practical Application

4.1 Before Starting Work

Before commencing any traffic management installation, ensure the following:

1. A Traffic Management Plan (TMP) has been authorised by the Road Infrastructure Manager (RIM).
2. All signs and devices have been loaded and checked against the Traffic Guidance Scheme (TGS).
3. Workers are familiar with the sequence and their responsibilities.

4.2 Covering Existing Signs

When covering existing speed signs, the following materials and methods are appropriate:

- Use opaque material approved in Main Roads Specification 601 - Signs.
- Do NOT use black plastic or similar materials - these can cause permanent damage to sign faces within 24 hours due to heat absorption and moisture retention.
- Ensure the covering is secure and will not come loose during the works.

4.3 Removing Coverings

When removing coverings from permanent signs:

1. Remove coverings carefully to avoid damaging the sign face.
2. Ensure the permanent sign is fully visible and legible before removing temporary signs.
3. Check that the speed limit shown matches the intended permanent limit.

5. Summary

The sequence for covering and uncovering speed signs is a critical safety procedure that ensures drivers always have a valid speed limit to follow. The correct sequence is:

Phase	Sequence
Installation	Install temporary signs → Cover permanent signs → Erect tapers
Removal	Remove tapers → Uncover permanent signs → Remove temporary signs

This sequence is mandated by AGTTM Part 3 and reinforced by the MRWA Code of Practice. Following this sequence ensures compliance with national and state standards, and most importantly, maintains safety for road users and traffic management personnel.

6. References

1. Austroads Guide to Temporary Traffic Management (AGTTM) Part 3: Static Worksites (2021), Page 114
2. Austroads Guide to Temporary Traffic Management (AGTTM) Part 6: Field Staff
3. Main Roads Western Australia Traffic Management Code of Practice (May 2025), Section 4.2.5 and Section 6.4
4. Australian Standard AS 1742.3 - 2019 Manual of uniform traffic control devices Part 3: Traffic control for works on roads